

Chapter 6 - Frivolous

It was merely pain, after all. The physical pain was nothing compared to the ache in her heart.

White light struck her cheek, but it wasn't accompanied by stabbing pain. A warm current flowed from her heart throughout her entire body. In everyone's eyes, it appeared like a celestial bird spreading its wings, scattering flying feathers and transforming that cold light into a gentle breeze.

Everyone else was shocked speechless. Ning Fuyi also widened her eyes, looking at her palms that had suddenly become smooth as snow.

When had such unfamiliar power appeared in her body?

But before she could gather her energy to investigate, the warm current from her heart disappeared, becoming as ordinary as if it had never existed.

"This..." Elder Pingyao had just begun to speak when her words were interrupted by an indifferent voice.

"Elder Pingyao." The person spoke, stepping forward so the light fell on her face.

The white figure seemed to have been standing there for a long time, her body completely shrouded in shadow. Only now, as she stepped forward and revealed her face, did she draw everyone's attention.

Elder Pingyao quickly made a gesture at her chest and bowed her head respectfully: "How embarrassing for the Divine Venerable to witness this. Fuyi, she..."

"No matter." Chu Qingqiu spoke. Her gaze fell on Ning Fuyi as if it had substance, pressing down on her shoulders with aching weight. Then she flicked her fingertip lightly, and the parasitic worm on Li Chaoan's wrist disappeared.

Li Chaoan was already so frightened she couldn't speak, her legs weak as if drained of strength, supported by other disciples nearby.

Ning Fuyi had noticed Chu Qingqiu long ago. Now she turned her head to stare at the ice coffin, avoiding Chu Qingqiu's gaze, still surprised by where that power had come from.

Looking at the other elders' expressions, they probably thought Chu Qingqiu had helped her block that strike. But she knew clearly that the power had definitely come from within her own body.

"Divine Venerable, Ning Fuyi used parasitic arts without authorization. This matter..." The male elder beside them still wanted to press the issue, but was interrupted by Elder Pingyao.

"Elder Jingshan, it's true that Ning Fuyi disregarded sect rules, but the hour is already late. If we don't gather the divine soul before sunrise, the Sect Master will never be able to reincarnate." Elder Pingyao said seriously. She glanced at Ning Fuyi. "The Sect Master is important—let's proceed with the guardian ritual first, then deal with punishment later."

"Elder Pingyao is right." Seeing her scheme succeed, Ning Fuyi smiled and stepped forward, taking the Eternal Lamp from her hands.

Seeing that she not only showed no remorse but had the audacity to act so shamelessly, Elder Jingshan beside her turned black with anger. However, he couldn't stop her and could only turn away in fury, out of sight, out of mind.

As Ning Fuyi passed by Chu Qingqiu's side, she suddenly heard a voice only the two of them could make out.

"Cultivators should prioritize the bigger picture and not focus only on immediate concerns. Your cultivation is weak and your body damaged—forcing yourself to serve as guardian is truly foolish." Chu Qingqiu said quietly, her words as cold as her expression.

Always preaching no matter what—Ning Fuyi felt disdain in her heart. This was what she hated most about Chu Qingqiu.

"What does the Divine Venerable consider the bigger picture? Handing over the chance to see my mother one last time to others, or like the Divine Venerable, watching coldly as relatives and friends pass away?" Ning Fuyi responded equally quietly.

Perhaps it was her imagination, but after she said this, Chu Qingqiu's breathing seemed to falter for an instant.

Ning Fuyi said no more. She walked directly to the ice coffin, raising the Eternal Lamp in her left hand while summoning immortal power with her right to slice through the air. A bloody wound appeared on her palm. She extended her hand over the lamp and clenched her fist forcefully—deep red blood dripped into the lamp's wick.

The flame instantly blazed bright, transforming from a bean-sized flame into something as brilliant as the sun. The observers all cried out and retreated. Li Chaoan, who was closest, nearly had her eyes burned and screamed as several elders protected her from behind.

The young girl in goose-yellow robes had a resolute, fearless expression, her movements decisive without hesitation—showing determination and composure that didn't belong to someone her age.

Chu Qingqiu's eyes seemed to surge with something, but the emotion passed in an instant.

Brilliant light and shadow burst from the small wick, accompanied by fierce winds in the room that made Ning Fuyi unable to open her eyes. The powerful force made the lamp base suddenly scalding hot, like a ravenous beast frantically absorbing the dripping blood.

Ning Fuyi felt her palm burning along with the lamp's wick, but she lacked the strength to summon immortal power to protect herself. She could only endure through willpower. The small wick seemed intent on draining all her strength, and unknown forces felt like they would scatter her bones.

The pain made Ning Fuyi nearly bite through her teeth. She closed her eyes, her body trembling, but refused to release the Eternal Lamp in her hands.

Seeing this scene, even Elder Pingyao seemed somewhat moved, lowering her eyes. Chu Qingqiu also closed her eyes slightly, concealing the expression in them, though her body remained perfectly still.

Someone nearby called out, and at the same time, shadow-like mist finally appeared above the ice coffin. White mist gathered gently from all directions, thread by thread.

Ning Fuyi's cheeks were deathly pale, drained of color and nearly unconscious, sustained only by willpower.

Her body swayed for a moment. Chu Qingqiu beside her suddenly fluttered her sleeves, and white silk flew from within, gently wrapping around Ning Fuyi's waist.

The white mist grew denser, finally condensing into a palm-sized cloud that slowly descended and settled into the lamp's wick.

The scene before Ning Fuyi's eyes suddenly changed. The dizzying bright light abruptly disappeared, replaced by a fairyland-like realm where the ground was made of clouds, soft as cotton that her feet sank deep into.

A person stood before her, wearing close-fitting light blue cotton robes, hair bound in a topknot high on her head, standing with her back turned.

"Ning Changfeng." Ning Fuyi murmured.

Seeming to hear her words, the person turned around. Those familiar gentle eyes immediately filled Ning Fuyi's eyes with tears that fell in large drops.

How long had it been since she'd seen her—over a thousand years? She used to find this face annoying, but after a thousand years of not seeing it, she found herself wanting to look again.

"How can a daughter of mine, Ning Changfeng, be crying like this?" Ning Changfeng spoke as she did in memory, her face full of disdain, though her hand lifted to brush past Ning Fuyi's eyes.

"Ning Changfeng." Ning Fuyi spoke again. She didn't want to cry either—what dignity was there for the world's first demon king to be sobbing like this?

But she couldn't help it.

"Alright, Mother has to go. If I keep listening to your crying, it'll disturb my path to reincarnation." Ning Changfeng said. She turned to leave, then seemed to remember something and raised her hand to touch Ning Fuyi's forehead.

Flying feather-shaped white light splashed like water, transforming into fireflies and dissipating. Ning Changfeng was first shocked, then curved her lips into a smile, quickly withdrawing her hand.

"Yiyi¹. Fuyi departs far away—may you have peace and joy." Ning Changfeng said with a smile.

As soon as she finished speaking, her figure became blurred, then gradually transparent. At the same time, the Eternal Lamp's flame began to flicker, its piercing light dimming. The ancestral hall returned to its usual state—empty and quiet.

Everyone knew the guardian ritual was over and finally relaxed. However, just as they were preparing to approach and check, Ning Fuyi suddenly took a step forward directly toward Chu Qingqiu, opened her arms, and forcefully pulled her into an embrace.

Chu Qingqiu hadn't expected such a move from her and was caught off guard, suddenly falling forward with her chest crashing into warmth and dampness.

Her eyes widened slightly, momentarily stunned.

The elders nearby, seeing Ning Fuyi's frivolous behavior, were all shocked speechless, frantically stepping forward to take the Eternal Lamp and reaching out to pull Ning Fuyi away, but were stopped by Chu Qingqiu's raised hand.

"Divine Venerable, this..." Elder Pingyao spoke fearfully.

"No matter." Chu Qingqiu said lightly. Her face fell into shadow, making her expression unreadable, yet she made no other movements.

The young girl's body was thin and delicate, but her tears were alarmingly abundant, flowing like a flood as she buried herself in that chest.

Ning Fuyi seemed to have fallen into an illusion. She cried quietly and silently, yet her hands domineeringly encircled Chu Qingqiu's waist, as if mistaking her for someone else, refusing to let go no matter what.

She only reached Chu Qingqiu's shoulder in height, so everyone watched helplessly as the legendary cold-faced Divine Venerable was used like a cushion, carelessly smeared with tears and snot across her chest.

Footnotes:

¹ **Yiyi (衣衣)** - This is the affectionate nickname Ning Changfeng uses for Ning Fuyi, derived from the "yi" (衣) character in her name. The repetition makes it more endearing, similar to how "daddy" is more affectionate than "father" in English.